

Friday, 24 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Overcast 28° 20°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 26° 15°	MANCHESTER Overcast 22° 16°	GLASGOW Light drizzle 18° 15°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

A group of millionaires, including former England footballer Gary Lineker, have written to new Prime Minister Andy Burnham, urging him to tax them more.

They believe they can afford to contribute more to the country's finances. This comes as the new government looks at ways to address the UK's economic challenges.

POLITICS · UK
- 2

Former DUP leader Jeffrey Donaldson has been stripped of his knighthood by King Charles III.

This follows his conviction in June on 18 counts of child sex abuse. The decision reflects the severity of the crimes and the impact on the honours system.

CRIME · UK
- 3

Millions of households across the UK are now under hosepipe bans as drought conditions continue to worsen in some areas.

More than eight million homes are affected, raising questions about water management. Parts of Wales have officially declared a drought after weeks of dry weather.

ENVIRONMENT · UK
- 4

Oil prices have surged to \$100 a barrel for the first time since May, following an escalation in the Middle East.

Brent crude rose more than 6% on Thursday, impacting global markets. This increase could lead to higher fuel costs for consumers and businesses.

ECONOMY · UK
- 5

Former Conservative MP Grant Shapps has been blocked from standing again for the party in the next election.

Tory leader Kemi Badenoch stated she is leading a 'new party full of new people'. This move signals a significant shake-up within the Conservative ranks.

POLITICS · UK

What's coming up

1 Actress Jaime Winstone, known for her roles in EastEnders and Made in Dagenham, has joined the line-up for Strictly Come Dancing.

She is the eighth celebrity confirmed for the upcoming series. Fans are already speculating about her potential dance partner and how far she might go.

ON AIR – What kind of dance do you think Jaime Winstone will be best at?

TV · AUTUMN

2 DJ Fatboy Slim is among investors helping to save a much-loved Brighton music venue, The Pipeline.

He's joined by new Prime Minister Andy Burnham in efforts to buy the venue's home. It's fantastic news for the grassroots music scene and local culture.

ON AIR – Are there any local music venues you think are vital to your town?

MUSIC · ONGOING

3 Love Island: All Stars winners Molly Smith and Tom Clare have tied the knot!

The couple, who won the spin-off series in 2024, have officially married. It's a lovely success story for the reality dating show.

ON AIR – Do you think reality TV couples have a better chance of lasting nowadays?

TV · RECENT

4 Oasis have officially overtaken The Beatles in the all-time UK album chart, marking a huge milestone.

This incredible achievement was revealed on the 70th anniversary of the album chart. It's sure to reignite the classic debate between fans of both iconic bands.

ON AIR – Who do you think is the more influential band: Oasis or The Beatles?

MUSIC · RECENT

5 The new film 'The Odyssey' has inspired a surge in interest for Homer's original epic poem.

Book sales and audiobook figures have risen sharply since the movie's release. It's wonderful to see a classic story finding a new audience through cinema.

ON AIR – Has a film ever made you want to read the book it was based on?

FILM · RECENT

On the schedule

- 1 Manchester City have completed the £116m signing of Elliot Anderson on a five-year deal.**
 The England player is tipped to become a 'complete midfielder' for his new club. It's a huge move for City as they strengthen their squad.
ON AIR – Do you think Elliot Anderson will live up to his 'complete midfielder' potential at Man City?
 FOOTBALL · UK
- 2 Olympic silver medallist Katarina Johnson-Thompson has pulled out of the Commonwealth Games due to injury.**
 This is a big blow for Team England and for the Games themselves. She will be sorely missed in Glasgow.
ON AIR – How much of a difference do you think Katarina Johnson-Thompson's absence will make to Team England's medal hopes?
 ATHLETICS · UK
- 3 Neither Old Trafford nor Headingley will host a men's Ashes Test between England and Australia next summer.**
 The full 2027 schedule has been released, confirming the northern grounds will miss out. This decision has sparked debate among cricket fans.
ON AIR – Are you surprised that Old Trafford and Headingley won't host an Ashes Test next summer?
 CRICKET · UK
- 4 Welsh Fire suffered a dramatic collapse in their opening Hundred match, losing five wickets for just six runs.**
 They fell to an eight-run defeat against Southern Brave in the women's competition. It was a thrilling start to the tournament.
ON AIR – What's the most dramatic sporting collapse you've ever witnessed?
 CRICKET · UK
- 5 Newcastle have agreed a £34m deal for Monaco midfielder Aladji Bamba.**
 Bamba is due to arrive for a medical and to sign a long-term contract. This looks like a significant signing for the Magpies.
ON AIR – Do you think Aladji Bamba will be a good fit for Newcastle's midfield?
 FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new trend sees people transforming ordinary garden sheds into cosy mini-retreats and workshops.**
No longer just for tools, these 'shed-cations' are becoming popular for reading nooks, craft spaces, or even tiny home offices, offering a peaceful escape right in the back garden.
- 2 Research suggests that listening to the sound of 'distant church bells' can evoke feelings of nostalgia and peace.**
Scientists found that the gentle, rhythmic chimes can have a surprisingly calming effect, often bringing back fond memories of quieter times and Sunday strolls.
- 3 The humble 'hot water bottle' is seeing a stylish resurgence, becoming a comforting accessory for chilly evenings.**
Beyond just warmth, new designs and luxurious covers are making them a must-have item for hygge-inspired living, proving some classics never go out of style.
- 4 A study reveals that people who 'talk to their houseplants' often find them thriving more.**
While the plants might not understand, the act of engagement often means gardeners are paying closer attention to their needs, resulting in healthier, happier greenery.
- 5 There's a growing appreciation for the 'art of skipping stones' as a mindful outdoor activity.**
More than just a childish game, enthusiasts are rediscovering the simple joy and meditative focus of finding the perfect stone and watching it dance across the water.
- 6 Scientists have found that looking at photos of 'cute animals' can actually improve concentration and performance on tasks.**
A Japanese study showed that participants made fewer errors after viewing images of puppies and kittens, suggesting a boost in mood and attention.
- 7 The simple pleasure of 'baking bread from scratch' is experiencing a significant rise in popularity across all age groups.**
The tactile process, the comforting aromas, and the delicious result are drawing more people into their kitchens to create their own homemade loaves.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to find something we've lost, even though we know it rarely helps?

ANSWER: ACCUSING AN INANIMATE OBJECT OF 'MOVING' IT.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a nice, freshly made sandwich. What is it?

ANSWER: PRESSING DOWN FIRMLY ON THE TOP SLICE OF BREAD TO 'SEAL' IT.

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes a particular 'sound' just instantly takes you back to a specific time of year, almost like an audio calendar?

From the crunch of autumn leaves to the distant buzz of a summer lawnmower, what everyday sound instantly tells you which season it is?

- Think about those 'little everyday rituals' that make a mundane task surprisingly enjoyable.

Whether it's how you make your morning tea or the specific order you load the dishwasher, what small ritual adds a bit of unexpected joy to your day?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Octopuses have three hearts: two pump blood through the gills, and one circulates it to the rest of the body.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** A group of pugs is charmingly called a 'wriggle'.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£3.6 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.6 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- A bolt of lightning is six times hotter than the surface of the sun.
- The world's smallest commercially produced car is the Peel P50, which is only 137 cm long.
- Butterflies taste with their feet.
- The inventor of the Pringle chip can is buried in one of them.
- The human nose can remember 50,000 different scents.
- Mount Everest grows by about 4 millimetres every year due to tectonic plate movement.
- The 'sixth sick sheik's sixth sheep's sick' is one of the toughest tongue twisters in the English language.
- A group of flamingos is known as a 'flamboyance'.

On this day

Day 205 of the year, 160 days left in 2026. Today Carnival of Awussu (Tunisia); Children's Day (Vanuatu); Christian feast day: Charbel (Maronite Church/Catholic Church); Christian feast day: Blessed Christina the Astonishing. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1951 — Lynda Carter, American actress
- 1949 — Michael Richards, American actor and comedian
- 1936 — Mark Goddard, American actor (died 2023)
- 1942 — David Miner, American singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1952 — Gus Van Sant, American director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1971 — Patty Jenkins, American film director and screenwriter
- 1966 — Martin Keown, English footballer and coach
- 1973 — Amanda Stretton, English racing driver and journalist

THE DAY TODAY

- 1987 — US supertanker SS Bridgeton collides with mines laid by IRGC causing a 43-square-meter dent in the body of the oil tanker.
- 1982 — Heavy rain causes a mudslide that destroys a bridge at Nagasaki, Japan, killing 299.
- 1943 — World War II: Operation Gomorrah begins: British and Canadian aeroplanes bomb Hamburg by night, and American planes bomb the city by day. By the end of the operation in November, 9,000 tons of explosives will have killed more than 30,000 people and destroyed 280,000 buildings.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 2001 — The Bandaranaike Airport attack is carried out by 14 Tamil Tiger commandos, resulting in military and civilian casualties and destroyed aircraft.
- 1999 — Air Fiji flight 121 crashes while en route to Nadi, Fiji, killing all 17 people on board.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1967 — During an official state visit to Canada, French President Charles de Gaulle declares to a crowd of over 100,000 in Montreal: Vive le Québec libre! ("Long live free Quebec!"); the statement angered the Canadian government and many Anglophone Canadians.

- 1929 — The Kellogg–Briand Pact, renouncing war as an instrument of foreign policy, goes into effect (it is first signed in Paris on August 27, 1928, by most leading world powers).
- 2012 — Syrian civil war: The People's Protection Units (YPG) capture the city of Girkê Legê.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 206 of the year, 159 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Anne (Eastern Christianity); Christian feast day: Carmen Salles y Barangueras; Christian feast day: Christopher (Western Christianity); Christian feast day: Cucuphas. Star sign Leo, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1991 — Toni Duggan, English footballer
- 1965 — Marty Brown, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1969 — D. B. Woodside, American actor
- 1971 — Roger Creager, American singer-songwriter
- 1979 — Ali Carter, English snooker player
- 1966 — Maureen Herman, American bass player
- 1967 — Matt LeBlanc, American actor and producer
- 1958 — Thurston Moore, American singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1984 — Salyut 7 cosmonaut Svetlana Savitskaya becomes the first woman to perform a space walk.
- 1971 — The Sohagpur massacre is perpetrated by the Pakistan Army.
- 1993 — Israel launches a massive attack against Lebanon in what the Israelis call Operation Accountability, and the Lebanese call the Seven-Day War.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2019 — National extreme heat records set this day in the UK, Belgium, The Netherlands and Germany during the July 2019 European heat wave.
- 1993 — The Saint James Church massacre occurs in Kenilworth, Cape Town, South Africa.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026

4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow

AUGUST 2026

W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)